STRATEGY CASE · AGENTIC COMMERCE · DATA & AI

Trust is the new *checkout*

How Visa can turn AI shopping agents from a pilot into a habit.

Kyi Sin Thant

WHY THIS QUESTION

With real money on the line, what would make people let an AI agent pay for them?

Visa has already built the rails for AI agents to pay. I wanted to understand what it would take for people to actually use them, and what Visa's Data & AI team could do about it.

THE SHORT VERSION

The rails are built. *Trust* is what's missing.

WHAT'S HAPPENING

AI agents have started buying for people.

- Morgan Stanley expects **$190B to $385B** of US spending to run through shopping agents by 2030.
- That's **10% to 20%** of US e-commerce.
- Visa, Mastercard, OpenAI and Google have all launched ways for agents to pay.

WHAT I FOUND

The revenue is modest. The position is big.

- In my 2030 base case, about **$99B** of agent spending would run on Visa's network.
- That earns Visa about **$278M** in net revenue, under 1% of its FY2025 net revenue of $40.0B.
- Only **6%** of shoppers would let an AI buy without checking in first.

WHAT I RECOMMEND

Make control visible to shoppers.

- Put agent limits and approvals inside the banking apps people already use.
- Start with everyday baskets **under $100**.
- Give every agent purchase a clear way to fix mistakes.

WHAT'S HAPPENING

In about a year, AI agents went from *suggesting* products to *paying* for them

Apr 2025

Visa Intelligent Commerce

Agent-specific card tokens, passkeys and spending limits

Sep 2025

OpenAI Instant Checkout

Buy inside ChatGPT, built with Stripe on the Agentic Commerce Protocol

Sep 2025

Google AP2

A protocol for proving an agent is allowed to pay

Oct 2025

Visa Trusted Agent Protocol

With Cloudflare, so merchants can tell good agents from bots

Apr 2026

Intelligent Commerce Connect

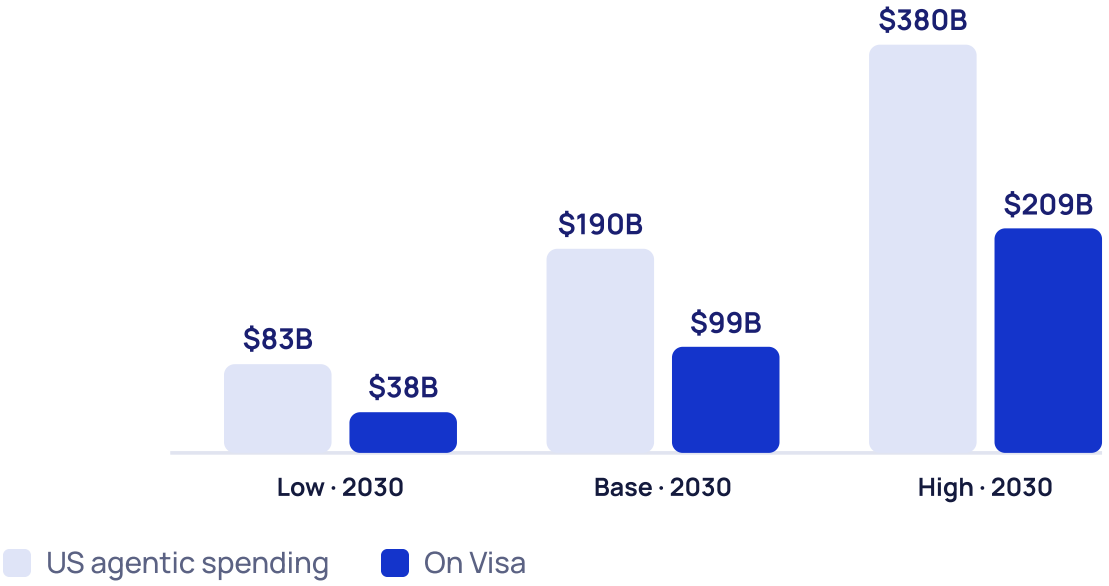
One on-ramp that supports the major agent protocols

4,700%+ Growth in AI-driven traffic to US retail sites over one year, reported by Visa in October 2025. Every major player now has a protocol, so the rails are no longer the hard part.

Gold dots are Visa launches. Sources: Visa newsroom, OpenAI, Google, partner releases.

HOW BIG IT GETS

By 2030, about *$190B* of US spending could run through AI agents. Roughly half of it on Visa.



	US e-commerce in 2030 $1.23T in 2025 (Census), grown 6% a year	**$1.65T**
×	11.5% bought through AI agents Matches Morgan Stanley's 2030 base case	**$190B**
×	85% paid with card credentials My assumption; the rest goes to bank transfers and other rails	**$161B**
×	61% Visa's share of US card spending Nilson Report, 2024	**$99B**

Low: slow adoption
5% of e-commerce through agents, 75% on cards

Base: most likely case
11.5% through agents, 85% on cards

High: fast adoption
23% through agents (Morgan Stanley bull case), 90% on cards

All three are 2030 projections. Sources: US Census Bureau, Q4 2025 e-commerce; Morgan Stanley, Nov 2025; Nilson Report, 2024. Full model in the Excel file.

WHAT IT'S WORTH

The revenue is small. *Being the default* is what counts.



Visa net revenue from US agentic spending, 2030

0.3% to 1.5%
of Visa's FY2025 net revenue ($40.0B), even in the high case

$46M a year
for every 10 points of agentic card share in the base case

Every purchase
an agent makes defaults to whichever credential it holds. Losing that slot is the real risk.

Net revenue yield = FY2025 net revenue / payments volume (0.28%), a global blend used as a rough proxy.

WHAT'S IN THE WAY

People will let an agent shop. They want *a limit and a way out.*



6% would let AI buy automatically without checking in
Worldpay, 8 countries, 2025

55% are uncomfortable with agents buying for them
Riskified, US and UK, Q1 2026

51% would blame the AI platform when it gets it wrong
Riskified, Q1 2026

69% would let an agent spend up to $100 on groceries and essentials
Global Payments, 2026

Comfort jumps when the purchase is small, routine and capped.

The pattern in every survey: a hard no to open-ended spending, a clear yes to everyday baskets with a limit. That's where to start.

OPTIONS

Three ways Visa could play

OPTION	BUILDS SHOPPER TRUST	FITS VISA'S PARTNERS	USES VISA'S DATA	SPEED TO IMPACT
A. Launch a Visa shopping agent Compete for the shopper directly	◐	○	◐	○
B. Keep widening the rails More protocols and partners. Needed, and already underway	○	●	◐	●
C. Make control visible to shoppers Limits, approvals and fixes where people manage money RECOMMENDED	●	●	●	◐

● Strong ◐ Partial ○ Weak Option A competes with the issuers and AI platforms Visa depends on.

RECOMMENDATION · THREE STEPS, IN ORDER

Put the controls *where people already manage their money*

STEP 1 · BUILD THE CONTROLS

An "Agents" screen in every issuer's app

- See every agent using your card
- Set a spending limit per agent
- Approve big buys with a passkey
- Switch an agent off in one tap

Built on Visa's existing agent tokens and passkeys, so issuers add a screen, not a new system.

STEP 2 · LAUNCH SMALL

Start with the everyday basket

- Groceries and household refills
- Orders under $100
- Repeat purchases that build the habit fast

69% of shoppers are already comfortable here. Morgan Stanley puts these categories at 19% of 2030 agent spending.

STEP 3 · BACK IT UP

A clear fix when an agent gets it wrong

- One dispute path for every agent purchase
- Visa's record shows what the agent was allowed to buy and what it bought

Half of shoppers would blame the AI platform today. Visa can be the neutral record that settles it.

Data & AI team's part: agent-level spending signals, risk scores for issuers, and a consent-first data policy with the Chief Privacy Officer.

HOW WE'D KNOW IT'S WORKING

A 90-day pilot with *four numbers* to watch

1

Enrollment

Share of cardholders who add an agent after seeing the controls screen

2

Repeat use

Share who make a second agent purchase within 30 days. The real test of trust

3

Hands-off rate

Purchases completed inside the limit with no manual approval needed

4

Dispute rate

At or below regular online card purchases, or the controls aren't working

WHO	WHAT	DECISION
2 digital-first issuers, 1 agent partner	Groceries and household refills, under $100	Scale if repeat use grows and disputes stay low

RISKS AND WHAT I'D TEST FIRST

What could go wrong

Issuers move slowly

Banking app changes take time.

Test: start with two digital-first issuers and a shared design Visa provides.

Controls add friction

Too many prompts and people give up.

Test: smart default limits that need no setup, approvals only above the limit.

Agents skip cards

Bank transfers or stablecoins could win the agent slot.

Test: keep supporting every protocol through Intelligent Commerce Connect.

Privacy concerns

Sharing purchase data with agents can feel invasive.

Test: consent-first sharing, written with the Chief Privacy Officer, explained in plain words.

SOURCES AND METHOD

Where the numbers come from

US e-commerce, 2025
US Census Bureau, Quarterly Retail E-Commerce, Q4 2025: $1,233.7B

Visa card share
Nilson Report, Feb 2025: Visa 61.1% of US card spending in 2024

Consumer trust
Worldpay (2025), Riskified (Q1 2026), Global Payments (2026)

Visa financials
Visa FY2025 Form 10-K: $40.0B net revenue, $14.2T payments volume

Agentic forecast
Morgan Stanley, reported Nov 2025: ~$190B base, ~$385B bull, 2030

Visa agentic products
Visa newsroom: Intelligent Commerce (2025), Trusted Agent Protocol (2025), Intelligent Commerce Connect (2026)

Method: 2030 e-commerce × share bought through agents × share paid by card × Visa's card share × net revenue yield, in three scenarios. Every input and formula is in the Excel model. The consumer surveys asked different questions, so I compare them side by side and don't merge them into one number.